The Sydney Morning Herald

Breaking Politics Federal Trump diplomacy

# Albanese accused of appeasing Donald Trump with move to allow US beef in

Nick Bonyhady and Paul Sakkal

Updated July 24, 2025 — 8.56am, first published at 7.07am

Listen to this article
5 min

The federal government has lifted its longstanding de facto ban on US beef, addressing one of the key trade complaints that President Donald Trump used to justify his tariffs on Australia while starting a fight with the Nationals.

Since 2019, Australia has allowed US beef into the country but had concerns about cattle born in Mexico and Canada that was slaughtered in America, resulting in no beef coming from the US to Australia because supply chains are largely integrated between the countries.




Anthony Albanese had said Australia would not compromise on biosecurity while Donald Trump demanded access for US beef. ALEX ELLINGHAUSEN, AP

This masthead revealed last month that the Albanese government was considering lifting the restrictions on US access to Australia's beef market via a biosecurity review amid trade talks between the two countries over Trump's 10 per cent import tariff.

Agriculture Minister Julie Collins said in a statement on Thursday morning that the government would not compromise on biosecurity but that a departmental review had completed a rigorous scientific process before recommending the change to import rules for beef.

"The Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry is satisfied the strengthened control measures put in place by the US effectively manage biosecurity risks," Collins said. "Australia stands for open and fair trade – our cattle industry has significantly benefited from this."

Trump and his commerce secretary had sharply criticised Australia's rules on beef imports, which were designed to keep Australia free of diseases found in cattle overseas.

"Our farmers are blocked from selling almost anywhere … Australia won't let us sell beef," US Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick said in April.

Nationals leader David Littleproud said the party would wait for a full briefing from the government before forming a final view of the biosecurity change, but he said Albanese

appeared to have caved in to Trump's demands.

"It looks as though [biosecurity] has been traded away to appease Donald Trump," Littleproud said on ABC's Radio National.

"With something as serious as biosecurity, we can't allow that to happen.

"We've been flat-footed in trying to deal with President Trump," Littleproud said, adding that it appeared the beef move was being used to "catch up at the expense of biosecurity".

Cattle Australia chief executive Will Evans said on Thursday that he was not thrilled with the decision but acknowledged it had been done via a scientific process and was aligned with Australia's position as an open trading nation. It would not lead to large beef exports from the US to Australia, Evans said, because Australian beef was 50 cents a kilogram cheaper than the American product.

"The trade terms are not in favour of the US, the way this economy works is that we go to them," Evans told ABC Radio National.

"In terms of trade, there could be some that comes in, there could be some boutique products that come in, but in terms of volume … my expectations would be that if there were any volumes, they'd be very low."

Experts, including former inspector-general of biosecurity Helen Scott-Orr, told this masthead in April that Australia's disease-free status depended on strict biosecurity protocols.

"We do not use them [biosecurity protocols] as non-tariff trade barriers. When other countries query our biosecurity requirements, we have to justify them and show that we are applying proper controls to allow trade to all those countries to continue," Scott-Orr said.

*The Australian Financial Review* was first to report the ban being lifted. The US has established greater tracing of cattle to determine where they were raised, which is useful in the event of a disease outbreak.

In April, Albanese said he would negotiate with the US but would never undermine biosecurity.

"We will not weaken the measures that protect our farmers and producers from the risks of disease or contamination," he said at the time.

Opposition finance spokesman James Paterson called for more information from Albanese on the reasoning behind the government decision.

"Perhaps the prime minister has found a way through this problem. Perhaps he's found a way of ensuring that beef is only imported, that is raised and reared in the United States … but if he has, he should explain how he's done so," Paterson told Sky News this morning.

"He should stand up today and explain to the beef farmers of Australia that there is no risk for their biosecurity and that he hasn't watered it down. But if he has watered it down, I think this is what's going to be a very difficult one for the government to explain."

In a statement issued last month, the National Farmers' Federation warned against changes to biosecurity to appease the Trump administration.

"Let's be abundantly clear, our biosecurity isn't a bargaining chip. We have the world's best standards, backed by science, and that's how it needs to stay," federation president David Jochinke said.

**With Daniel Lo Surdo and Nick Newling**

***Cut through the noise of federal politics with news, views and expert analysis. Subscribers can sign up to our weekly Inside Politics newsletter.***

---

Was this article easy to read and understand?

---

**Nick Bonyhady** is the deputy federal editor of the Sydney Morning Herald and The Age, based in Parliament House in Canberra. He is a former technology editor and industrial relations reporter. Connect via Twitter.

**Paul Sakkal** is Chief Political Correspondent. He previously covered Victorian politics and has won Walkley and Quill awards. Reach him securely on Signal @paulsakkal.14 Connect via Twitter.